

TOURNAMENT FUEL

WHY 'I'M NOT HUNGRY'
ISN'T THE REAL ISSUE



YOUR ATHLETE ISN'T RESISTING FOOD. SHE'S MISSING THE CONNECTION BETWEEN FOOD AND FUEL.



THE SERIES

FIVE LESSONS. ONE PLAYER.

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Why 'I'm Not Hungry' Isn't the Issue

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Tournament Day Nutrition Basic

Coming up.

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Hydration: The Underrated Performance Variable

Coming up.

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Teaching Athletes to Own Their Fuel

Coming up.

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The Long-Game Lesson of Fuel

Coming up.

HEAR THIS ONCE

WHEN YOUR ATHLETE SAYS SHE'S NOT HUNGRY AT 5AM BEFORE A TOURNAMENT, SHE'S NOT BEING DIFFICULT. SHE'S MISSING THE CONTEXT THAT CHANGES EVERYTHING.

There's a fundamental difference between eating because you're hungry and eating to sustain physical activity. Your athlete hasn't made that connection yet, and once she does, she won't need convincing anymore.

THE FUEL CONNECTION

SHE DOESN'T NEED TO FEEL HUNGRY TO NEED FUEL. THOSE ARE TWO DIFFERENT THINGS — AND THIS LESSON IS ABOUT TEACHING THE DIFFERENCE.

→ Appetite: eating when the body sends hunger signals

→ Fuel: eating to sustain physical output, whether or not hunger is present

→ Tournament day changes everything: nerves suppress appetite, but energy demands are at their highest

— FUEL IS NOT ABOUT APPETITE. IT'S ABOUT PERFORMANCE PREPARATION.

05 · THE BREAKDOWN

THE A P P E T I T E T R A P

THE EARLY WAKE

4:30am wake-up + travel + nerves = appetite suppression. Expected. Not an excuse.

THE GAS-OUT

Playing a full match on no fuel leads to complete energy depletion by match two. Avoidable.

THE TEACHING WINDOW

One experience of the difference, fueled vs. unfueled, is more powerful than any conversation.



THE FUEL LESSON

IN PRACTICE

Let her experience one match on low fuel and one on proper fuel, then ask her to compare.

WATCH FOR

Complaints of brain fog, heavy legs, or inability to focus mid-tournament, these are fuel issues.

THE SHIFT

From forcing her to eat to helping her connect what she ate to how she performed.

02

07 · REMEMBER THIS

SAVE THIS COME BACK TO IT

YOU ARE NOT FEEDING HER APPETITE.
YOU ARE FUELING HER
PERFORMANCE. HELP HER
UNDERSTAND THE DIFFERENCE.

SAVE THIS. COME BACK TO IT.

THIS WEEK

THIS WEEK, RUN THE FUEL EXPERIMENT.

✓ At the next practice, note her energy level and ask her to rate it on a scale of 1-10

✓ Note what she ate beforehand, or didn't

✓ At the next match, ensure a proper pre-match meal and ask for the same 1-10 rating

✓ Let her make the connection herself, don't tell her. Ask her.



TOURNAMENT FUEL

TOURNAMENT DAY
NUTRITION BASICS

02

SIMPLE, CONSISTENT, AND TIMED RIGHT. THAT'S THE WHOLE STRATEGY.



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MOST TOURNAMENT NUTRITION
FAILURES ARE NOT ABOUT WHAT TO
EAT, THEY'RE ABOUT WHEN, AND
HOW TO MAKE EATING POSSIBLE
WHEN NO ONE FEELS LIKE IT.

The nutrition basics for tournament day are not complicated. The execution is the challenge, because early wake-ups, nerves, and long travel schedules create every condition that makes proper fueling feel impossible.

— SIMPLE AND CONSISTENT BEATS PERFECT AND NEVER · MAZEPERFORMANCE

THE TOURNAMENT NUTRITION PLAN

THE BEST TOURNAMENT NUTRITION PLAN IS THE ONE THAT ACTUALLY GETS EXECUTED. KEEP IT SIMPLE AND BUILD IT IN ADVANCE.

- Before the first match: carbohydrates for accessible energy, protein for sustained fuel
- Between matches: small, frequent, easily digestible, avoid heavy meals mid-tournament
- Hydration: starts the night before, not at the gym

— PREPARE THE FUEL BEFORE THE TOURNAMENT. DON'T FIGURE IT OUT ON THE DAY.

05 · THE BREAKDOWN

THE TOURNAMENT FUEL MAP

NIGHT BEFORE

Full meal + hydration. This is the prep that makes morning fuel easier.

MORNING OF

Simple carbs: toast, banana, oatmeal. Protein: eggs, Greek yogurt. Small but present.

BETWEEN MATCHES

Snacks over full meals: nuts, fruit, granola bar, half a sandwich, nothing heavy.



THE FUEL PACK

IN PRACTICE

Build a tournament fuel pack together the night before, both of you know what's in it and why.

WATCH FOR

Whether she eats between matches or skips because she 'doesn't feel hungry', address it with data.

THE SHIFT

From trying to feed her at the tournament to having a plan she understands before you leave the house.



07 · REMEMBER THIS

SAVE THIS COME BACK TO IT

TOURNAMENT NUTRITION IS DECIDED
THE NIGHT BEFORE. ON THE DAY, IT'S
JUST EXECUTION.

SAVE THIS. COME BACK TO IT.

THIS WEEK

THIS WEEK, BUILD THE TOURNAMENT FUEL PLAN.

✓ Sit down together the night before the next tournament and plan the fuel

✓ Build the pack together: snacks, water, timing notes

✓ After the tournament, ask: 'How was your energy today compared to last time?'

✓ Adjust the plan based on what worked, this is a living document



HYDRATION: THE UNDERRATED PERFORMANCE VARIABLE

03

MOST TOURNAMENT PERFORMANCE ISSUES ARE PARTIALLY HYDRATION ISSUES. FIX THIS FIRST.

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MOST PARENTS FOCUS ON WHAT
THEIR ATHLETE EATS AT
TOURNAMENTS, AND UNDERESTIMATE
THE IMPACT OF WHAT SHE DRINKS,
AND WHEN.

Dehydration begins before the athlete feels thirsty. By the time thirst signals arrive, performance has already been compromised. Tournament hydration starts the night before, not when the match begins.

— HYDRATION STARTS THE NIGHT BEFORE · MAZEPERFORMANCE

THE HYDRATION WINDOW

IF SHE'S DRINKING WATER WHEN SHE'S THIRSTY AT THE TOURNAMENT, SHE'S ALREADY BEHIND.

→ Night before: 16-20oz of water with dinner, start the day ahead

→ Morning of: water before anything else, before screens, before food

→ Tournament: consistent sips every 20-30 minutes, not reactive gulps when thirst hits

— THIRST IS A LATE SIGNAL. HYDRATE BEFORE IT ARRIVES.

THE DEHYDRATION COST

ENERGY

Mild dehydration (1-2%) reduces athletic performance measurably, before the athlete notices.

FOCUS

Decision-making and reaction time degrade under mild dehydration, invisible until the match reveals it.

RECOVERY

Hydrated athletes recover faster between matches, the advantage compounds across a long tournament day.



THE HYDRATION HABIT

IN PRACTICE

Set a hydration reminder for the night before every tournament, make it automatic, not reactive.

WATCH FOR

Dark urine, headache, or fatigue mid-tournament, these are dehydration signals that are already late.

THE SHIFT

From reactive drinking to proactive hydration, it's a habit built before the tournament, not at it.



07 · REMEMBER THIS

SAVE THIS COME BACK TO IT

HYDRATION IS A PERFORMANCE
DECISION MADE THE NIGHT BEFORE.
MAKE IT THEN, NOT WHEN SHE'S
ALREADY THIRSTY.

SAVE THIS. COME BACK TO IT.

THIS WEEK

THIS WEEK, INSTALL THE HYDRATION HABIT.

- ✓ Set a reminder: the night before any tournament, drink 16oz of water with dinner
- ✓ Morning of: water before screens, before food, first thing
- ✓ At the tournament: small bottle visible and accessible during warm-up and between matches
- ✓ Track energy and focus at each match, connect it to the hydration prep



TOURNAMENT FUEL

TEACHING ATHLETES
TO OWN THEIR FUEL



THE GOAL IS NOT COMPLIANCE. IT'S OWNERSHIP OF THEIR OWN PERFORMANCE PREPARATION.



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FORCING ATHLETES TO EAT
PRODUCES COMPLIANCE. TEACHING
THEM TO UNDERSTAND FUEL
PRODUCES OWNERSHIP, AND
OWNERSHIP LASTS.

The long-term goal is an athlete who understands her own body well enough to make smart fuel decisions without being told. This is a skill that takes a full season to develop, and lasts a lifetime.

— TEACH THE WHY BEFORE THE WHAT · MAZEPERFORMANCE

THE OWNERSHIP MODEL

ONCE SHE FEELS THE DIFFERENCE,
SHE DOESN'T NEED CONVINCING.
UNTIL THEN, TEACH THE WHY.

- Start with the why: what does her body need fuel for and why?
- Let her feel the difference: fueled match vs. unfueled match, she will notice
- Move to self-direction: 'What do you think you need to fuel this tournament?'

— COMPLIANCE IS TEMPORARY. OWNERSHIP IS PERMANENT.

THE OWNERSHIP ARC

PHASE 1

Parent-directed: you plan the fuel, she executes, with explanation of why each choice is made.

PHASE 2

Collaborative: you plan together, she contributes ideas, she is learning to read her own signals.

PHASE 3

Athlete-directed: she plans the fuel, you support, she owns her performance preparation.



MOVING THROUGH THE ARC

IN PRACTICE

Ask: 'What do you think your body needs the night before a tournament?' Let her answer first.

WATCH FOR

Whether she starts asking about fuel proactively, that's Phase 3 beginning to emerge.

THE SHIFT

From telling her what to eat to asking her what she thinks she needs, and teaching her to be right.



07 · REMEMBER THIS

SAVE THIS COME BACK TO IT

YOUR JOB IS TO TEACH HER TO READ
HER OWN BODY. NOT TO BE HER CHEF
FOREVER.

SAVE THIS. COME BACK TO IT.

THIS WEEK

THIS WEEK, MOVE UP ONE PHASE IN THE OWNERSHIP ARC.

- ✓ Assess: which phase are you in? Parent-directed, collaborative, or athlete-directed?
- ✓ Identify one thing you currently do for her that she could do herself with guidance
- ✓ Hand it to her, with the why, and let her execute
- ✓ Debrief: 'How did it go? What would you change next time?'



TOURNAMENT FUEL

THE LONG-GAME
LESSON OF FUEL

05

UNDERSTANDING YOUR BODY IS A LIFE SKILL. THIS IS WHERE IT STARTS.



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HEAR THIS ONCE

TOURNAMENT NUTRITION IS NOT THE POINT. THE POINT IS THAT YOUR ATHLETE LEARNS TO MAKE INTENTIONAL CHOICES ABOUT HER OWN BODY'S NEEDS, AND THAT SKILL WILL SERVE HER LONG AFTER VOLLEYBALL.

A young woman who understands that her body is a system requiring intentional inputs: sleep, hydration, nutrition, recovery, is an athlete who becomes an adult with a competitive advantage in every domain she enters.

— BODY LITERACY IS A LIFE SKILL · MAZEPERFORMANCE

THE LIFE TRANSFER

YOU'RE NOT TEACHING HER TO EAT BEFORE A VOLLEYBALL TOURNAMENT. YOU'RE TEACHING HER TO UNDERSTAND HER OWN BODY.

→ Body literacy: knowing what her body needs and when, before performance, after stress, during recovery

→ Decision-making: choosing fuel intentionally rather than reacting to cravings or pressure

→ Self-advocacy: knowing how to communicate her needs, to coaches, teammates, future employers

— THE ATHLETE WHO UNDERSTANDS HER BODY BECOMES THE ADULT WHO TAKES CARE OF IT.

WHAT SHE'S ACTUALLY LEARNING

ANTICIPATION

She is learning to anticipate her body's needs, not just respond to them.

INTENTIONALITY

She is learning that choices about her body are choices about her performance and her energy.

ADVOCACY

She is learning to name what she needs and to ask for it, a skill most adults struggle with.



MAKING IT EXPLICIT

IN PRACTICE

After a well-fueled tournament, ask: 'What did you understand about your body today that you didn't before?'

WATCH FOR

Whether she's beginning to connect her energy and focus to her preparation choices.

THE SHIFT

From 'eat your food' to 'what does your body need today?', the question that teaches body literacy.

02

07 · REMEMBER THIS

SAVE THIS COME BACK TO IT

TEACH HER TO READ HER BODY LIKE
AN INSTRUMENT, AND SHE WILL PLAY
IT BETTER FOR THE REST OF HER
LIFE.

SAVE THIS. COME BACK TO IT.

THIS WEEK

THIS WEEK, HAVE ONE BODY LITERACY CONVERSATION.

- ✓ Ask: 'What signals does your body give you when you're properly fueled versus not?'
- ✓ Help her articulate specific signals: energy, clarity, heaviness, brain fog
- ✓ Connect those signals to specific choices: what did she eat, when, how much water
- ✓ Build this into a post-tournament debrief habit: 'How did your body feel and what caused it?'

